a recognized political party at the federal level – who also wanted a say, directly or indirectly, over gurudwara affairs to further their interests. In the March 1975 elections, the CPC(ML) lent its support to Kuldip Singh Samra for the president's post. Having lost, Samra filed an appeal in a local court. When he lost the case there too he opened fire in court, killing one and wounding another. [11]

Given the above environment, I started building my contacts with important persons from the local Sikh (about half the population of about 5,000 persons of Indian origin) community in Ottawa. Fortunately, the president of the local gurudwara committee, Sardar Ganda Singh, was an old family friend from India. In Ottawa, a monthly function was held at the Memorial High School on Viewmont Drive. The religious ceremony was followed by Shabad Kirtan by Sikh children. Depending on the importance of the occasion, in the end a short speech on a relevant subject was made by someone from the local Sikh community. Ganda Singh, who knew about my knowledge of Punjab affairs and Sikh history, would often ask me to speak. This would happen every three to four months. I soon started getting invitations from prominent members of the local Sikh community to attend functions and social get-togethers at their homes.

My local Punjabi friends, both Sikhs and Hindus, were first-generation immigrants. They were educated and worked as professionals or federal government employees. At social get-togethers, I noticed that they tended to be aware of developments taking place in Punjab and, as was the case back home, they held divergent views on the happenings in Punjab or India. Due to my speeches at the local gurudwara, quite a few Sikh/Punjabi drivers from the local ABC taxi service came to know me rather well. Travelling in their taxis provided me with greater insight about their views on what was happening in Punjab. They would normally refuse to accept payment at the end of the journey but would finally relent when I told them I was being paid by the government for that journey. I also attended a couple of marriage receptions hosted by them.

During one of my visits to Toronto I had a detailed discussion with our consul general M.L. Suri, an experienced officer. We